

Cyber Threat Report

Threat Report ID: UoL-CTI-25-0729

Date: 29 July 2025

Reported by: UoL Cyber Threat Intelligence Group

Threat level: High

Summary

A sophisticated phishing and ransomware campaign is currently targeting UK-based higher education institutions. The campaign, attributed to a financially motivated threat group known as 'Vulcan Hydra', is designed to gain access to university networks, exfiltrate sensitive data and demand cryptocurrency payments for decryption.

1. Threat actor profile

- Name: Vulcan Hydra (suspected Eastern European origin)
 - Motivation: Financial gain
 - Tactics: Phishing, credential theft, lateral movement, data exfiltration, ransomware deployment
 - History: Involved in similar campaigns targeting research institutions in 2023–2024
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2. Attack vector

- Initial access
Phishing emails impersonating university HR departments. Subject lines reference updated payroll systems and require staff to verify details via a malicious link.
 - Payload
Once credentials are entered, a dropper downloads HydraCrypt, a custom ransomware variant capable of:
 - encrypting shared drives and cloud-based repositories
 - stealing browser-saved credentials
 - disabling endpoint recovery tools.
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3. Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

- Malicious domains:
 - o university-payroll-check[.]com
 - o hrportal-verify[.]org
 - IP addresses:
 - o 185.203.119.74 (linked to previous HydraCrypt attacks)
 - o 92.118.160.22 (command and control node)
 - Hashes of detected payloads:
 - o e3b0c44298fc1c149afbf4c8996fb924... (HydraCrypt v3.2 installer)
 - o f2d5e8ff9ec11817f9a1283d736b0143... (phishing attachment .docm)
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4. Timeline of activity

Date	Activity
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12 July	First phishing email reported by a staff member
14 July	Network scans from known Hydra IPs detected
15 July	Two faculty accounts compromised
16 July	Suspicious lateral movement observed on research subnet
18 July	Ransom note detected in shared drive

5. Impact (observed at peer institution)

- Partial data encryption of research archives
 - Three-day outage of internal file-sharing systems
 - Loss of six months of unbacked-up admin records
 - £50,000 ransom demanded (not paid)
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6. Intelligence source assessment

Source	Reliability	Confidence
Internal incident logs	High	High
UK NCSC advisory (13 July)	High	High
OSINT from sector forum	Moderate	Moderate
Vendor-provided threat feed	High	Moderate

7. Notes

- No evidence of data being leaked on dark web forums (as of 28 July)
- Vulcan Hydra known to return to previously exploited targets
- HydraCrypt has evaded detection by at least two major antivirus engines